

Tux on PS2

Sony is getting ready to release Linux OS kits.

The company aims at helping Linux programmers develop applications based on the OS for the PS2. Starting May 2002, disks for installation of the OS and tools for developing applications for PS2 will be available commer-



cially. The company plans to roll out the gaming console as an extended version with more common applications such as word processing and spreadsheet capabilities. Wait for the Tux to make its way into the game console market and you can start expecting some surprises.

Yours Vociferously

Usable voice recognition technology, after a lot of talk, has finally made an appearance. Dragon's Speech recognition software, version 6, has been launched in India featuring new technologies like NBS (Nothing But Sound), a tool that filters out fillers and intervals between dictations. This helps in the removal of unwanted words like 'umm' and 'uhh' which usually

occur during dictation. Another great feature is the Acoustic Optimizer, which allows the software to learn from all the data that it has accumulated over time in order to render greater recognition accuracy. With Dragon Speech, connecting to hyperlinks, controlling the mouse, editing, etc are easy tasks—all you have to do is speak. Now if somebody will tell us the price...

Hands-free Mouse

Track IR hands-free mouse helps the physically challenged use the computer with relative ease.

This device is suitable for people suffering from carpal tunnel syndrome. The mouse kit ships with a silver dot and a sensor—the sensor is an IR device that connects to your USB port and the silver dot is the medium through which the sensor picks up the reflection in



order to move the cursor on the screen. The silver dot could be stuck on to your forehead (or any other part of your body that you can use to comfortably move the mouse). As you move your head, the silver dot moves along, and the IR sensor picks up the reflection from the sticker. The sensor then sends the data to move the cursor accordingly on the screen.

Studying genes with DNA computers

Olympus has released a practical DNA computer that can be used in the analysis of genes. A normal computer works on electrical impulses to process information, but the DNA computer relies on chemical reactions between fragments of DNA.

Multiple chemical reactions between strands of DNA can happen simultaneously leading to massive parallel computing capability. This capability is used in the DNA computer developed by Olympus to analyse genes, a task that requires enormous computing power.

The company developed the product in a joint venture called NovousGene which specialises in genome informatics. The computer



is divided into two segments—the Molecular Calculation component and the Electronic Calculation component.

The former analyses the genes, initiates chemical reactions and brings out DNA results while the latter does the extreme processing and analysis of the final results.

Olympus plans to test run the computer for a complete year and then hopes to provide the services in early 2003 on a commercial basis.

Flaw discovered in MSN

A hidden feature in MSN Messenger allows Internet Explorer users to be identified on the Microsoft Web sites. A clever netizen has found that a small VBScript or JavaScript code can easily reveal the user's details. The malicious feature can be abused by any Web master to obtain your username along with all the contacts. If the code fails to fetch the username it fetches the e-mail ID of the user and his contacts, making the situation worse. A small piece of software can make a registry entry in your

computer that can throw open your messenger details



to its associated Web site. This malicious program can introduce a .org, .com or any other domain suffix to the registry and allow any site in that domain to access your Messenger details.